

RESIDUAL

A DUNE SIDE STORY

CHARACTERS: THUFIR HAWAT, BARON VLADIMIR HARKONNEN, FEYD-RAUTHA HARKONNEN, IAKIN NEFUD

FADE IN:

INT. HARKONNEN KEEP, ARRAKEEN, PRIVATE CHAMBER, NIGHT

The room still carries the bones of Atreides architecture: green tile underfoot, a faded outline on one wall where a hawk crest was pried away and never quite replaced. Harkonnen purple hangs over it now, cheap and a size too small for the space it covers.

THUFIR HAWAT sits at a low table covered in reports and sand-charts. He is old. Not frail, but worn the way a blade is worn, thinned by use rather than time. His lips are stained dark red from the sapho juice that keeps a Mentat's mind clear, but there is a second stain beneath it, greyer, that has nothing to do with sapho.

His eyes go distant. Pupils fully black. He is running numbers no one in the room could follow.

A GUARD enters without knocking, carries a tray: water, a portion of unspiced gruel, and a small vial of dark liquid.

GUARD

Nefud says drink it before it settles.

Hawat's eyes clear. He looks at the vial the way a man looks at a debt he did not choose to owe. He drinks it in one motion, without expression, and hands the empty vial back.

HAWAT

Tell Nefud his timing has improved. Four minutes early today.

GUARD

He'll take that as a compliment.

HAWAT

It wasn't one.

The guard leaves. Hawat returns to his charts. A beat of stillness, the first honest moment we've seen from him, gone the instant the door opens again.

BARON VLADIMIR HARKONNEN enters, suspensors humming, his great bulk drifting a few inches off the floor so that he never quite has to carry himself. FEYD-RAUTHA trails a step behind, young, coiled, watching Hawat the way a boy watches an animal he has been told is dangerous but has never seen bite.

BARON

Thufir. Still awake. I admire a man who doesn't waste the hours I've given him.

HAWAT

You haven't given me hours, Baron. You've given me a schedule.

BARON

(delighted)

Semantics. Even in captivity he corrects me.

He settles into the air across from Hawat, folding his hands over his stomach.

BARON (CONT'D)

The spice harvest in the southern basin. Three runs disrupted this month. My foreman believes the desert people are becoming bolder.

HAWAT

Your foreman believes what frightens him least to report. The pattern doesn't support boldness. It supports information. Someone is telling them which routes to watch.

BARON

And who would tell them that, Thufir?

HAWAT

I don't know. If I did, I'd have already used it against you rather than telling you about it.

A short, ugly laugh from the Baron. Feyd doesn't laugh. He steps closer, studying Hawat's face like a text he's trying to translate.

FEYD-RAUTHA

He talks to you like an equal, uncle. I wouldn't allow a captured dog to talk to me that way.

HAWAT

(not looking at him)

A dog doesn't do arithmetic for you at three in the morning, young master. That's the difference between us. Keep insulting me and you'll have to learn subtraction yourself.

FEYD-RAUTHA

(a flash of real anger, controlled)

You served a dead Duke. Remember what that got him.

HAWAT

I remember. I was there for most of it. Were you?

The Baron watches this exchange with real pleasure, the pleasure of a man who enjoys nothing more than two useful things testing each other's edges.

BARON

Enough. Thufir, the projections. I want the probability that the Fremmen can be broken within a year. A real number. Not a comfortable one.

Hawat's eyes go distant again. The room waits.

HAWAT

Given known population estimates, water discipline, and terrain advantage: low. Below one in five. If you want a comfortable number, ask a man who isn't a Mentat.

BARON

And if I increase patrols? Double the sweeps through the deep desert?

HAWAT

Then you'll lose more men to the desert than to the Fremmen, and the number gets worse, not better. You're welcome to ignore that. Most men in your position do.

BARON

(a long look, something colder underneath the humor)
You say that as if you'd enjoy watching me ignore it.

HAWAT

I'm a Mentat, Baron. I don't enjoy things. I calculate them.

The Baron studies him a moment longer, then waves a hand, dismissing the tension like smoke.

BARON

See that the new figures are on my desk by morning. Feyd. Come.

They go. Hawat sits alone with the charts, and for the first time we see his hand tremble, very slightly, before he steadies it and goes back to work.

INT. HARKONNEN KEEP, HAWAT'S CHAMBER, LATER THAT NIGHT

Hawat alone. He takes a small, cheap ring from beneath a floor tile, hidden without ceremony, plain metal with a scratched hawk pressed into it. Not the ducal signet, something smaller, something a man might have carried without anyone else knowing its meaning. He turns it over once.

HAWAT

(quiet, to no one)

Run the numbers again. What does loyalty cost when the man you owed it to is dead and the men left don't deserve it.

He waits, as if the room might answer.

HAWAT (CONT'D)

No good number for that. File it under unsolved.

He puts the ring away and returns to the charts.

INT. HARKONNEN KEEP, AUDIENCE CHAMBER, DAY

The Baron reclines, Feyd near a window, IAKIN NEFUD standing at attention, a career soldier with the tired eyes of a man who has learned not to ask questions above his rank. Hawat stands before them, hands folded.

BARON

There's a matter I want your professional opinion on, Thufir. Not a projection. A judgment.

HAWAT

I'll do what I can with the difference.

BARON

Lady Jessica. The Duke's woman. Piter believed, before his usefulness ran out, that she may have sold her own household to us. That the attack succeeded as cleanly as it did because someone inside opened the door.

Hawat's face doesn't change. This is old ground for him, and older grief.

HAWAT

Piter believed a great many things that were convenient for Piter.

BARON

Convenient or not, was he wrong?

A long pause. This is the question Hawat has turned over more nights than the Baron will ever know, back when it still mattered whether the answer was true rather than merely useful.

HAWAT

I served that household for thirty years. I trained her guard, planned her security, ate at her table more often than I ate at my own. I have no proof she was loyal. I also have no proof she wasn't. A Mentat doesn't invent data to fill a gap. He reports the gap.

BARON

That's not an answer.

HAWAT

It's the only honest one available. If you want comfort, ask Feyd. He's better at telling you what you want to hear.

FEYD-RAUTHA

(stung)

Watch yourself, old man.

HAWAT

(evenly)

I've been watching myself for longer than you've been alive. It's the only luxury they haven't taken from me.

The Baron considers this, drumming thick fingers on the arm of his suspended chair.

BARON

Keep the doubt alive, Thufir. Whether she betrayed us or not, I find the uncertainty useful. It keeps the household afraid of its own shadow, and a household afraid of its own shadow doesn't organize against me. You understand.

HAWAT

(something flickers, buried fast)

Perfectly. Uncertainty is cheaper than truth and does more work. I've built my whole career on knowing that.

BARON

Good. Then we understand each other.

He doesn't. Hawat's stillness says everything his face won't.

EXT. ARRAKEEN, SOUTHERN PATROL ROUTE, DAY

A column of Harkonnen troops moves along a ridge road through broken rock, NEFUD at their head, following a route marked on a chart Hawat prepared the night before. Wind. Heat shimmer. The kind of terrain that swallows sound before it travels far.

Nefud checks the chart against the landscape.

NEFUD

Hawat's route again. Man's never wrong about ground.

SOLDIER

Wish he'd be wrong just once. Feels like walking into someone else's plan.

Nefud doesn't answer that. He should have.

The column rounds the ridge. From higher ground, unseen, the first shots come. Chaos. The scene doesn't linger on the violence, cuts before it becomes spectacle, but the outcome is clear: the patrol did not choose this ground. It was chosen for them.

INT. HARKONNEN KEEP, AUDIENCE CHAMBER, NIGHT

The Baron is not delighted now. Feyd stands rigid near the wall. Hawat stands where he always stands, hands folded, waiting.

BARON

Twelve dead. On a route you drew yourself.

HAWAT

Yes.

BARON

Explain that to me, Mentat.

HAWAT

The probability of ambush on that route, based on all data available to me at the time, was under three percent. I gave you the honest number. You accepted it. Low probability isn't zero probability, Baron. If you wanted certainty, you should have hired a prophet instead of a Mentat. I only deal in odds.

BARON

(barely controlled)

Convenient, that the odds failed you this particular week.

HAWAT

Odds fail people every week. That's what makes them odds and not promises. If you'd like, I can show you the calculation again. It hasn't changed. Only the outcome has, and outcomes and probabilities are not the same animal, whatever your foreman tells you when he's frightened.

A long, dangerous silence. Feyd watches his uncle's fury with real interest, and something else too, a private calculation of his own beginning to take shape behind his eyes.

BARON

(finally, controlled again)

Get out. Recalculate the routes. All of them.

HAWAT

As you say.

He turns to go. At the door, Feyd's voice stops him.

FEYD-RAUTHA

Hawat.

Hawat turns back, waits.

FEYD-RAUTHA (CONT'D)

You didn't even blink when he accused you.

HAWAT

Blinking wouldn't have changed the number,
young master. I've found it's a wasted motion.

He leaves. Feyd watches the door a long moment, something new and cold settling into his expression, the beginning of an idea about exactly what kind of tool a man like Hawat might become, in the right hands, aimed the right direction.

INT. HARKONNEN KEEP, HAWAT'S CHAMBER, NIGHT

Hawat alone again. He takes out the small ring, turns it in the lamplight. His hand is steadier now than it was before. He sets it down and, for a moment, simply looks at his own hands, as if checking whether they still belong to him.

Beat.

HAWAT

(quiet)

Run it again. What is the cost of being useful
to men you'd rather see dead.

HAWAT (CONT'D)

There's a number for that too. I just haven't
decided yet whether I want to know it.

The door opens. The Guard again, with the tray, the vial. Right on schedule. Hawat looks at it the way he might look at a debt collector he has learned, patiently, to outlast.

HAWAT (CONT'D)

(taking the vial)

Tell Nefud he's three minutes early tonight.

GUARD

Does that bother you?

HAWAT

No. It tells me he's starting to worry about something. I like knowing that more than I like the antidote.

He drinks it anyway. The lamp gutters. He returns to the charts, and to the long, patient arithmetic of a man deciding, one small omission at a time, exactly how his service will end.

END